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# OREGON STATE PARKS VOLUNTEER-PROGRAM CONTROLS

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| TO        | Senator Kate Lieber and Representative Tawna Sanchez, Co-Chairs, Joint Committee on Legislative Audits |
| FROM      | Robert Samuel White, P.O. Box 334, Reedsport, Oregon 97467                                             |
| DATE      | September 23, 2026                                                                                     |
| RE        | Request for audit consideration: OPRD volunteer-program controls                                       |
| TESTIMONY | v1.10                                                                                                  |

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I am Robert Samuel White. I served as an unpaid volunteer with the Oregon Parks and Recreation Department at Jessie M. Honeyman Memorial State Park.

On March 5, 2025, the park manager and the park supervisor sat me down at a picnic table for sixty-two minutes. I recorded the meeting ([Testimony v1.10, p. 181](#)). On March 24, 2025, OPRD dismissed me as a volunteer.<sup>6</sup> On March 26, 2025, its letter permanently excluded me from every OPRD volunteer program, citing my public comments about staff.<sup>7</sup>

On August 24, 2025, I published an open letter to the Director of Oregon State Parks.<sup>1</sup> I asked for five protections for every volunteer who serves the institution: an investigation when misconduct is documented; consequences for managers who coerce volunteers; protection from retaliation for volunteers who report; a grievance process that does not run through the people causing the harm; and training and oversight for the people who supervise volunteers.

The institution's answer to a volunteer seeking accountability was the police. On March 3, 2026, it sent my letters to an Oregon State Police captain,<sup>8</sup> and on March 24, 2026, one year to the day after the dismissal, two OSP detectives and a Forest Service special agent came through a locked federal gate to the work center where I live and work.<sup>8</sup> Their own file closed: "there is no evidence White has committed any crimes."<sup>8</sup>

More than a year later, not one of the five protections exists. Oregon State Parks operates a statewide volunteer program in which volunteers serve with no written standards, no notice, no hearing, no appeal, and no protection from retaliation. Volunteer hosts live on the land they serve, so a dismissal is also a displacement. Mine came with twenty-four hours to vacate ([Testimony v1.10, p. 258](#)). My record is the proof of each absence, and all of it is public. On September 21, 2026, I asked the Secretary of State's Audits Division to consider a performance audit of these controls.<sup>2</sup> I ask the committee to recommend that audit.

The investigation. On August 25, 2025, the Director replied that she took concerns about the volunteer program seriously and would make sure my concerns were reviewed through the appropriate channels within the Department. Her response did not identify the channel, the person responsible for the review, the standard that would govern it, or how I would be told its result.<sup>3</sup> On December 8, 2025, she wrote that further correspondence would lead nowhere<sup>4</sup> and closed the correspondence that afternoon.<sup>5</sup> No letter of hers reported a completed review, identified a finding, or named a corrective action.

The consequences. The conduct I documented, in writing and in recordings, produced no identified consequence for any manager. The consequences fell on the volunteer who documented it: the dismissal, the displacement with twenty-four hours to vacate, the permanent statewide exclusion,<sup>7</sup> and, one year later, armed men at my home.<sup>8</sup>

The protection from retaliation. The exclusion letter cites my public comments about staff.<sup>7</sup> On March 3, 2026, OPRD Emergency Manager Jamen Lee sent my letters to Captain Kyle Kennedy, OSP Government and Media Relations, copying Deputy Director Collier: “Fyi – sharing for situational awareness since he is now including the Governor as well as our Director.”<sup>8</sup> On March 23, 2026, a detective opened a dispatch event naming me “Suspect,” with the basis: sending “concerning emails to former supervisors in parks department and publicly airing grievances.”<sup>8</sup> The volunteer who reported was the one investigated.

The grievance process. The only route ran to the people the grievance concerned. On August 22, 2025, I filed a public records request with OPRD;<sup>9</sup> on November 15, 2025, I served the Director notice that it had been held eighty-five days.<sup>10</sup> The Director herself was the final channel for the complaint, the records, and the fee decisions, and she closed the channel.

The supervision. The dismissal was delivered by phone, six days before my scheduled completion. No written standard governing volunteer supervision, discipline, or dismissal has ever been identified in any of the institution’s responses to me.

What the absences produced is in the Oregon State Police production of September 3, 2026, under PR27478, which I published in full.<sup>8</sup> On March 4, 2026, the dispatch record was entered: “Capt. Kennedy is requesting that a threat assessment be conducted asap.”<sup>8</sup> The assessment went to the Major Crimes Section and to a detective who is a task force officer with the Portland FBI Joint Terrorism Task Force. He forwarded my name to FBI personnel and pulled my driver’s record through the task force.<sup>8</sup> On March 11, 2026, a fusion center analyst at the Oregon Department of Justice documented me, writing that my actions “border on harassment due to the volume of emails that he has forwarded to OPRD staff over the last year.”<sup>8</sup> On March 24, 2026, one year to the day after the dismissal, two OSP detectives and a Forest Service special agent came through a locked federal gate to the work center where I live and work.<sup>8</sup> On April 15, 2026, the case-lead detective closed the assessment: “Ultimately White does not appear to be escalating on the pathway to violence,” and “there is no evidence White has committed any crimes.”<sup>8</sup>

The five protections are control objectives. Their absence is documented above, in the institution’s own letters and the file its referral created. I ask the committee to consider the questions I placed before the Audits Division:

1. What process governs a complaint by an OPRD volunteer when the complaint concerns the volunteer’s supervisors?
2. What record must be created when the Director promises departmental review, and who verifies that the review occurred?
3. What standards and approvals govern an OPRD referral of a volunteer’s correspondence and public criticism to law enforcement?
4. What risk assessment, record-preservation, and after-action review controls apply when such a referral results in a Major Crimes investigation and a visit to the volunteer’s home and workplace?

The records are public. The archive at [oprdivolunteerabuse.org](http://oprdivolunteerabuse.org) preserves the correspondence as rendered documents and unmodified email originals, and every citation in this letter resolves to a source document. I ask the committee to recommend the audit, and to tell me if a different submission route is required.

Respectfully,

Robert Samuel White

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## Sources

1. [An Open Letter, August 24, 2025.](#)
2. [Request for Performance Audit Consideration, September 21, 2026.](#) The request now before the Audits Division.
3. [The Director's response to the open letter, August 25, 2025.](#)
4. [The Director's morning reply, December 8, 2025.](#)
5. [The Director's afternoon reply, December 8, 2025.](#)
6. [I was dismissed from Honeymen today, March 24, 2025.](#)
7. [Volunteering with Oregon Parks and Recreation Department, March 26, 2025.](#) The permanent exclusion letter.
8. [The records are produced, September 3, 2026.](#) The full PR27478 production.
9. [Public Records Request, Volunteer Program Operations and Management, August 22, 2025.](#)
10. [Notice of Violation, November 15, 2025.](#)